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Libyan politics

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The shaikh of all the Zuwaya was Ibrahim al-Sanusi, of Ahwaij lineage in Jlulat section. He was in his eighties, had been a member of parliament under the monarchy, and in 1979 lived a life of tranquil austerity in Ajdabiya. His house was near the centre of town, in a block with houses belonging to other members of Ahwaij and a mosque which they all used. Ibrahim's house was old, a rendered mud-brick construction with an interior courtyard. His guestroom had cushions rather than chairs, and occasionally he used it to store sacks of grain. On cool evenings Ibrahim would sit on the step of a small neighbourhood shop, listening to conversations among whoever might be there, making occasional comments, laughing at jokes, rarely saying more than a few words at a time. His style was different from the assertive, dominating busy-ness of Abdulnabi al-Hatash. This was partly a matter of age: Ibrahim was an old man, concerned with the next life, having no need to increase his influence. It was also a matter of character. People said he was always a reconciler, a man who did not support a bad case simply from personal connection. Abdulnabi said Ibrahim was the only Zuwayi you could trust; Ibrahim said nothing at all about Abdulnabi.

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If there was a dispute between people of different tribes, in theory each member of each tribe was involved. The people who made peace were the shaikhs of the lineages. But the peace had to be accepted by all members of the tribe, lest some other person not in the peace-making group would resurrect the quarrel; and people not in the lineages involved could be attacked. So the shaikhs of the whole tribe had to signify their assent to the terms of the peace. Ibrahim attended meetings to settle terms, and was a formidable presence there, calming the angry, stimulating the easy-going with

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stories of peaces made with inadequate bloodwealth, leading the offended party to a 102 demand for compensation which, while not outrageous, was enough to satisfy the offence. But Ibrahim took no part in organizing a political coalition of Zuwaya to run a list of candidates for elections. He did not consider elections to be inter-tribal conflicts, as Abdalnabi did. He left that task to the shaikhs of the five Zuwaya sections. They were not unanimous about many things, and failed to agree strategies and tactics for formal political action. So the Zuwaya found it difficult to present a united front to the Magharba coalition, and although they usually united at the last minute, by then it was often too late.

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